

Easter Offensive: Kontum

The security of the Central Highlands was a paramount concern for South Vietnamese and US strategists in early 1972. Loss of the Highlands and adjacent coastal plains would cut South Vietnam in two.

◀◀ BEFORE

From the start of the war, the Central Highlands had been a key area of conflict.

REPEATED ASSAULTS

In 1965 and in 1967, there was **major fighting** in the Central Highlands. The North Vietnamese used operations in this area to distract US and ARVN forces while they prepared for the **Tet Offensive**. This strategy was repeated two weeks before the start of the Easter Offensive when NVA units increased their activities in the area.

An attack from the west through the Central Highlands—Military Region (MR) 2—was one of the three prongs of attack that comprised North Vietnam’s plan for a spring offensive. For this advance, the North Vietnamese assembled three infantry divisions along with a tank unit, two artillery regiments, and three regiments of independent infantry—roughly 20,000 troops. The ARVN defenders included the 22nd and 23rd Infantry Divisions, widely regarded as the weakest in the ARVN. The South Vietnamese, aware of the threat, also posted a brigade of the ARVN Airborne Division to the region.

The ARVN benefited from a formidable US adviser, John Paul Vann, who was able to convince General Abrams to prevail upon the ARVN to send a second airborne brigade to the Highlands.

Even so, not every key point could be garrisoned. Rocket Ridge, which overlooked Route 14, the north-south backbone of the Highlands, had several firebases but it was still a tempting target for North Vietnamese forces looking to cut off Kontum from Dak To and Tan Canh, MR 2’s northerly outposts. Further preparations for the expected offensive included the deployment of additional ARVN forces from Pleiku to forward positions above Kontum.

“Even a tank we ‘destroyed,’ ... might be repaired to **fight again** another day.”

LIEUTENANT COLONEL THOMAS P. McKENNA, *KONTUM: THE BATTLE TO SAVE SOUTH VIETNAM*, 2011